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Definiteness in Korean and Beyond

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Introduction

- How human language marks definiteness has been at the center stage in recent linguistics literature.
- Due largely due to Schwarz (2009) and much subsequent work (e.g., Jenks 2015, 2018; Aguilar-Guevara et al. 2019; references there), we now know that:
 - Definites are at least of two kinds: e.g., unique definites (유일 한정 명사구) and anaphoric definites (조응적 한정 명사구).
 - Unlike English, other languages may mark unique definites differently than anaphoric definites: e.g.,
 - Weak (약) vs. strong (강) article distinction (정관사 구별) in German/Fering;
 - Bare noun (민명사) vs. demonstrative (Dem) (+ classifier (CL)) marked NP (지시사 결합 명사구) in Shan/Mandarin.

Some recent cross-linguistic findings

Type of definite use		English	German (Schwarz 2009)	Shan (Moroney 2021)	Mandarin (Simpson & Wu 2022; Dayal & Jiang 2023; Zhu & Ahn 2022; Ahn & Zhu 2024)
상황적	Immediate situation	<i>the</i>	Weak	Bare	Bare
	Larger situation	<i>the</i>	Weak	Bare	Bare
조응적	Typical anaphoric	<i>the</i>	Strong	Bare/Dem	Bare/Dem
	Bridging: Product-producer	<i>the</i>	Strong/Weak	Bare/Dem	Bare/Dem
	Bridging: Part-whole	<i>the</i>	Weak	Bare	Bare/Dem
	Donkey anaphora	<i>the</i>	Strong	Bare/Dem	Bare/Dem

Where does Korean fit in this picture?

- Recent research has shown that Korean behaves **a lot like Mandarin**.

Type of definite use		English	German (Schwarz 2009)	Korean (Cho 2016; Ahn 2019; Kang 2021; Kim 2021a,b; M. Park 2021; 박소영 2023; Park and Kang 2024)
상황적	Immediate situation	<i>the</i>	Weak	Bare
	Larger situation	<i>the</i>	Weak	Bare
조응적	Typical anaphoric	<i>the</i>	Strong	Bare/Dem
	Bridging: Product-producer	<i>the</i>	Strong/Weak	Bare/Dem
	Bridging: Part-whole	<i>the</i>	Weak	Bare/Dem
	Donkey anaphora	<i>the</i>	Strong	Bare/Dem

The problem

- On close inspection, the picture is **far more complicated** than what the tables on the previous slides represent or make us believe about Korean as well as about other bare noun languages:
 - For situationally used unique definites, typically, a bare noun is used, but a Dem-NP is not always prohibited.
 - In marking anaphoric definites, both a bare noun and a Dem-NP may be used but they are not always interchangeably used (Kim 2021a,b; 2023a,b; Kim & Lee 2023).
 - Moreover, there is a great deal of (inter-speaker) variation in grammaticality judgments, in particular, in using anaphoric bare nouns (see, e.g., Kim 2021a,b; 박소영 2023).

Illustration of the “cleaner” cases

- **Situationally unique definites**

- (1) (#그) 문 열어! (Immediate situation use)
- (2) (#그) 달이 떴다. (Immediate/Larger situation use)

- **Anaphoric definites**

- (3) Typical two-sentence narrative

가게 안으로 **어떤 소녀**가 들어 왔다. (그) 소녀는 가방을 들고 있었다.

- (4) Bridging : Product-producer

어제 **매우 재미있는 논문**을 읽었다. (그) 저자는 촌스키이다. (박소영 2023: (23다))

- (5) Bridging : Part-whole

우리 집은 매우 오래된 집이다. (?그) 지붕은 빗물이 센다. (박소영 2023: (22라))

- (6) Donkey-sentence

친구가 있는 모든 어린이는 ??/?(그) 친구에게 전화를 걸었다. (Kim 2021b: (21(c)))

Illustration of more problematic cases

- **Situationally unique definites**

(7) (There is only one book in the discourse context.)

(그) 책 좀 치워 줄래?

- **Anaphoric definites**

(8) (Speaking is talking about a particular email.)

친구가 어제 **이메일**을 보냈다. 나는 오늘 */??(그) 이메일을 읽었다.

(9) (Speaking is talking about a particular dog.)

동물 병원에서 **개 한 마리**를 봤다. *(그) 개가 가장 귀여웠다. (Kim 2023b: (10))

The outstanding question

- In marking definiteness in Korean, **when** is a **bare noun** chosen over a **Dem-NP** or **vice versa**?
- In the literature, this question has **not** received a fully satisfactory answer **yet**:
 - Pragmatic notions like *salience* (두드러짐), *topic-hood* (화제성), *contrast* (대조), and *familiarity* (친숙성) have been claimed, and seen, to play a role (e.g., Chang 1984; Ionin et al. 2012; Kang 2021; M. Park 2021, 2022, 2023; 박소영 2023). However, most existing analyses do not offer testable predictions within a formal framework.
 - Kim (2023b) attempts to account for the distributional and interpretive differences between anaphoric bare nouns and Dem-NPs within a formal semantic framework. But her data are limited to subject positions.

Goal of this talk

- To capture the difference between bare noun definites and Dem-NPs by applying the analysis proposed in Kim 2023b to non-subject anaphoric data, with implications for other languages.
- **What I will show:**
 - Kim's core ideas hold water: there are two types of anaphoric bare nouns; and while bare noun definites are sortally unique, Dem-NPs are locationally unique.
 - In marking anaphoric definites, the syntactic structure of the discourse at issue matters, as well as its information structure and discourse coherence.
 - Bridging cases may require a separate treatment than typical anaphoric cases because they involve possessor (PR) nominals which may be null or are realized external to the possessum (PM) nominals.

Outline of the talk

- Brief intro to Kim 2023b
- How Kim's (2023b) analysis may account for anaphoric definiteness marking in Korean and in other languages, in comparison to some recent works on the topic.
- Summary and conclusion

Intro to Kim 2023b

- Kim (2023b) looks at only **two-sentence narrative sequences** in which the first sentence (S_A) contains an **indefinite nominal** (비 한정 명사구), and the second sentence (S_D) contains an **anaphoric definite** (한정 명사구) that is co-indexed with the indefinite and occurs as a nominative (NOM) or topic (TOP) marked subject.

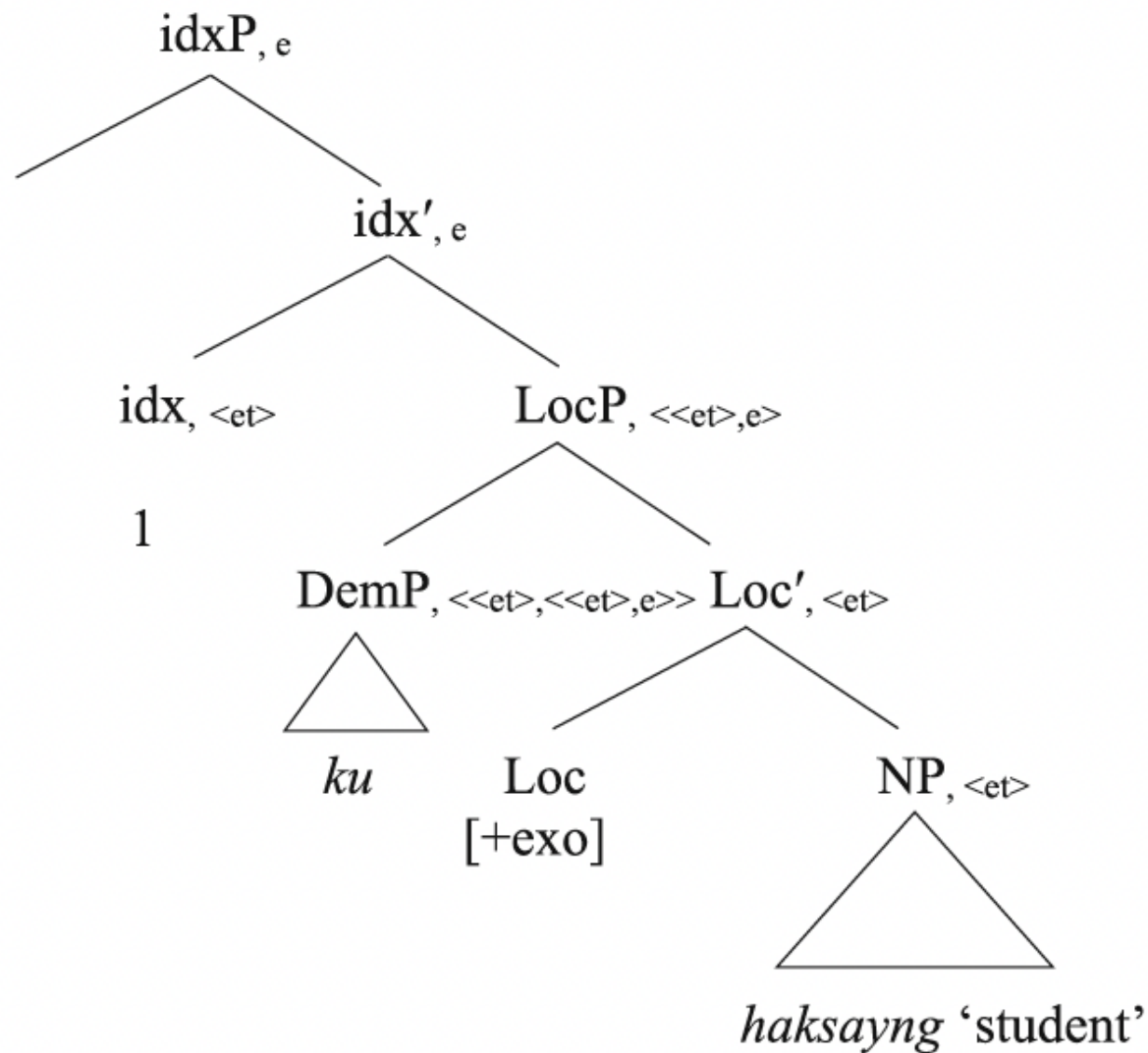
[Text	[S_A ...	[indefinite NP]₁	]	[S_D	[definite NP-NOM/TOP]₁	]	]
		비 한정 명사구			한정 명사구-주격/화제어 조사		
		source situation (s_s)			resource situation (s_r)		
		원천 상황			본 상황		

Key claims of Kim 2023b

- Dem-NPs and anaphoric bare nouns have a **different distribution** and **interpretation**: 즉, 둘은 자유변이를 보이지 않는다.
- Unlike anaphoric definites, **Dem-NPs** are **exophoric** (+exo) (언어/상황 외적), as opposed to **endophoric** (+end) (언어/상황 내적).
- Some anaphoric bare nouns mark situation-internal (상황 내적) property-based uniqueness; some mark text-internal (텍스트 차원의) property-based uniqueness.
- **All anaphoric definites** have a similar syntax and are semantically of the same type.
 - They all host a **Locative Phrase** (LocP) (공간구) in the sense of Kim (2019), which is comparable to a referential DP.
 - They all carry an **Index Phrase** (idxP) (지표구) which is syntactically projected above LocP.
 - They all contain an **operator** of type $\langle\langle\text{et}\rangle,\langle\langle\text{et}\rangle,\text{e}\rangle\rangle$, be it phonologically null (i.e., the iota operator ι '아이오다 연산자') or not (i.e., a Dem '지시사').

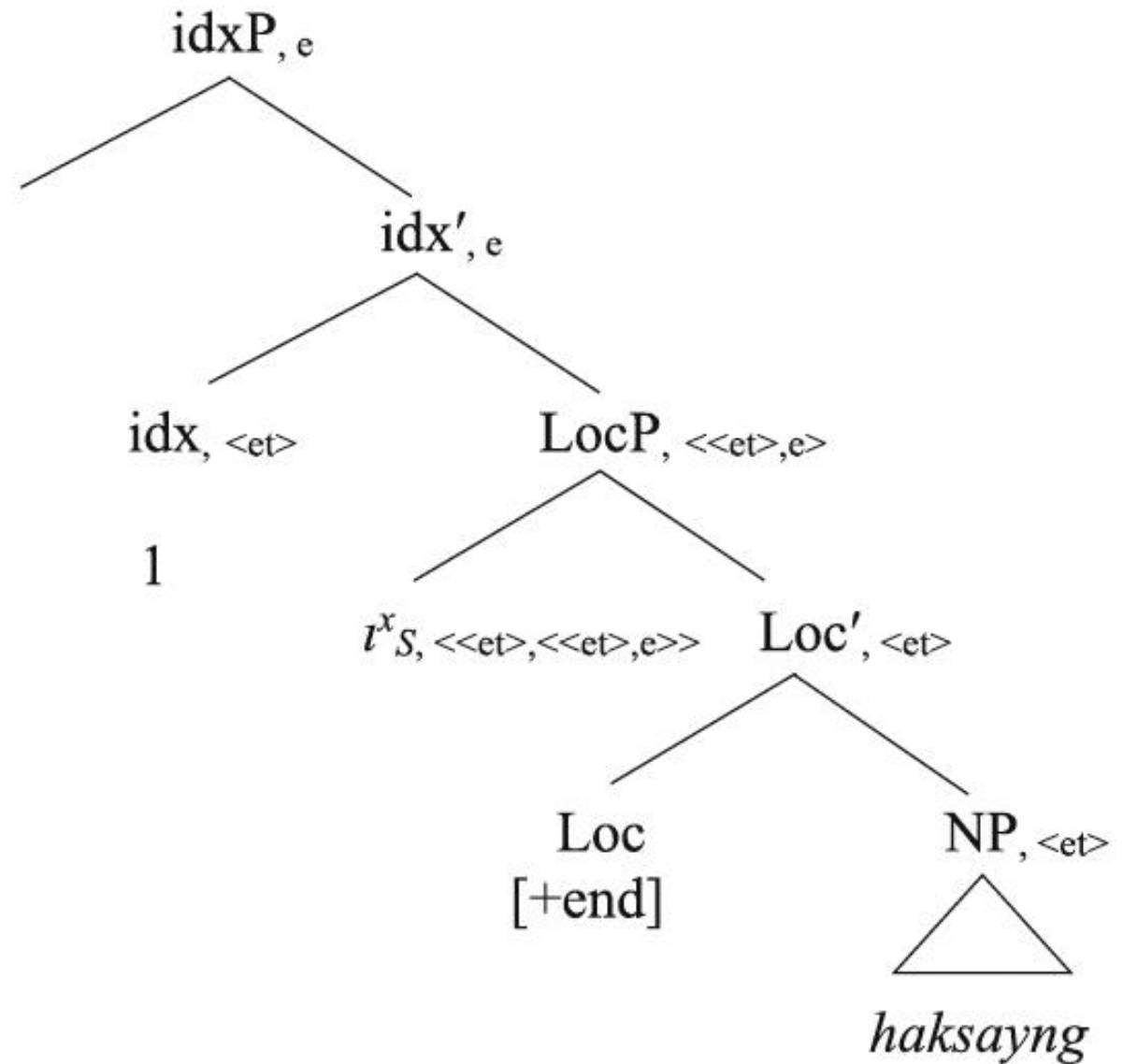
Structure of a Dem-NP “그 학생”

(Kim 2023b, (29a))



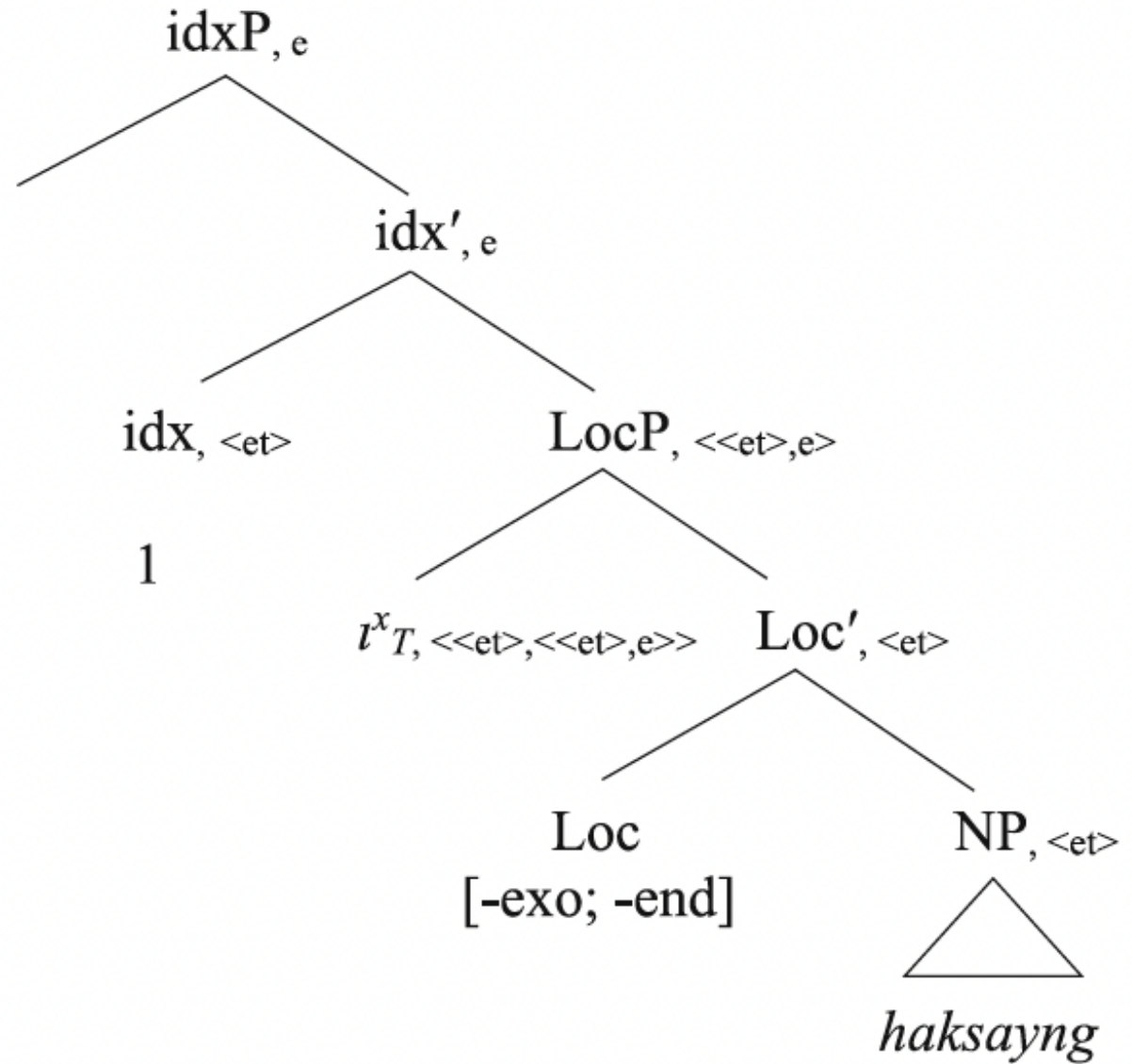
Structure of a
situation-internally
unique anaphoric
bare noun “학생”

(Kim 2023b, (30a))



Structure of a
text-internally
unique anaphoric
bare noun “학생”

(Kim 2023b, (31a))



Semantics of anaphoric bare nouns in Korean

(10) Licensing conditions for anaphoric bare nouns (조응적 민명사구가 쓰이는 조건)

- a. when s_s and s_r share the spatio-temporal location, and there is some individual y overtly introduced in s_s such that y differs from individual x denoted by the anaphoric definite at issue, and x and y have different properties P and Q ; or
- b. when the speaker uses an anaphoric bare noun as a quasi-name at the text (T) level.

(Kim 2023b: (21))

(11) Semantics of anaphoric bare nouns (조응적 민명사구의 의미)

- a. $[[l^x_s]]^g = \lambda P_{\langle \text{et} \rangle} . \lambda G_{\langle \text{et} \rangle} : \exists ! x [P(x)(s_s) \ \& \ s_s \propto s_r \ \& \ \exists y [y \neq x \ \& \ Q(y)(s_s) \ \& \ Q \neq P]] .$
 $\quad \quad \quad \iota x [P(x)(s_r) \ \& \ \exists y [y \neq x \ \& \ Q(y)(s_r) \ \& \ Q \neq P] \ \& \ G(x)]$
- b. $[[l^x_T]]^g = \lambda P_{\langle \text{et} \rangle} . \lambda G_{\langle \text{et} \rangle} : \exists ! x [\text{known-as-}P(x)(T)] . \iota x [\text{known-as-}P(x)(T) \ \& \ G(x)]$

(Kim 2023b: (22))

Semantics of Dem-NPs in Korean

(12) Licensing conditions for Dem-NPs (지시사 결합 명사구가 쓰이는 조건)

- a. when conditions (21a) and (21b) in Kim 2023b are not met; *or*
- b. when there is a need for the speaker to indicate a locative relation (LR) between them (i.e., the speaker) and the individual denoted by the definite at issue in s_r .

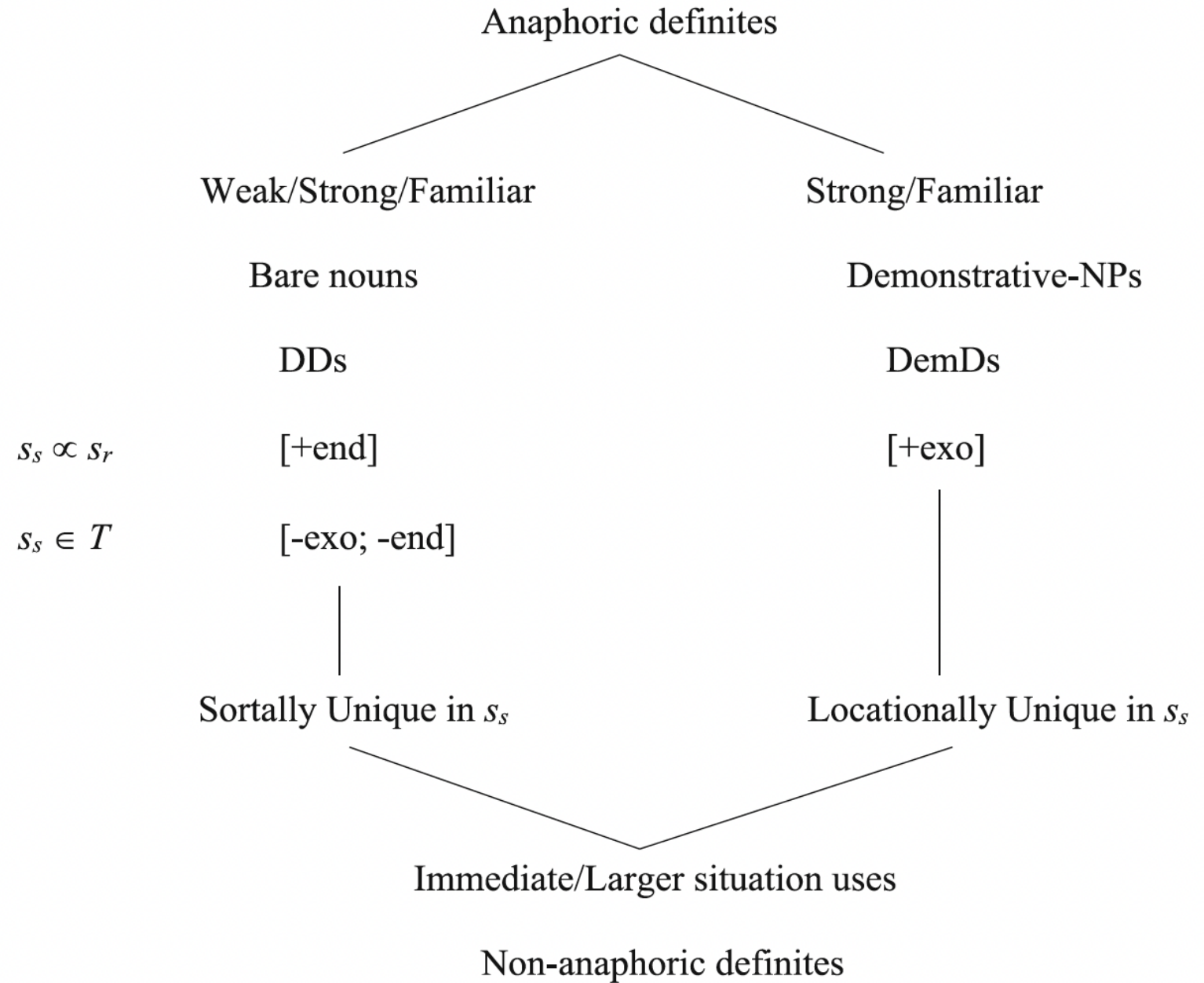
(Kim 2023b: (25) with annotations)

(13) Semantics of demonstratives (지시사의 의미)

$$\llbracket \text{Dem} \rrbracket^g = \lambda P_{\langle \text{et} \rangle} . \lambda G_{\langle \text{et} \rangle} : \exists ! x [P(x)(s_r) \ \& \ LR(x)(y)(s_s)] . \iota x [P(x)(s_r) \ \& \ LR(x)(y)(s_r) \ \& \ G(x)]$$

(Kim 2023b: (26))

Kim's classification of definites in Korean



(Kim 2023b, (44))

Application of Kim's proposal to anaphoric subject data

- Kim's analysis explains the following anaphoric subject data in Korean:

(14) When s_s introduces **just one** individual and $s_s \propto s_r$: (10a) is **not** met.

- a. 교실 안으로 **남학생 한 명**이 들어온다.
- b. ?/??(**그**) **남학생**은 스무 살 정도 되어 보인다.

(Kim 2023b: (9))

(15) When s_s introduces **two** individuals and $s_s \propto s_r$: (10a) **is** met.

- a. 교실에 **남학생과 여학생**이 앉아 있다.
- b. (**그**) **남학생**은 스무 살 정도 되어 보인다.

(Simpson & Wu 2022: (30))

Application to anaphoric subject data cont'd

(16) When s_s introduces **three** individuals and $s_s \propto s_r$: (10a) **is** met.

- a. 동물 병원에서 **개 한 마리와 고양이 한 마리** 그리고 **햄스터 한 마리**를 봤다.
- b. **(#그)** 개가 가장 귀여웠다. (Kim 2023: (16))

(17) When s_s introduces **just one** individual and $s_s \propto s_r$: (10a) **is not** met.

- a. 동물 병원에서 **개 한 마리**를 봤다.
- b. ***(그)** 개가 가장 귀여웠다. (Kim 2023: (10))

- In (17), “그” is required because the superlative meaning of “가장 귀여웠다” requires the existence of multiple individuals and the semantics of a Dem conventionally implicates the existence of an individual that is not overtly introduced in s_s in s_r (compare Dayal & Jiang 2023).

(13) $\llbracket \text{Dem} \rrbracket^g = \lambda P_{\langle \text{et} \rangle}. \lambda G_{\langle \text{et} \rangle}. \exists ! x [P(x)(s_r) \ \& \ LR(x)(\textcolor{red}{y})(s_s)]. \cdot 1x [P(x)(s_r) \ \& \ LR(x)(\textcolor{red}{y})(s_r) \ \& \ G(x)]$

Application to anaphoric subject data cont'd

(18) When s_s introduces just one individual and $\sim[s_s \propto s_r]$

a. 어제 **개 한 마리**를 봤다.

b. 오늘 #/??(**그**) **개**가 집에 왔다.

(Kim & Lee 2023: (11))

(19) When s_s introduces just one individual and $\sim[s_s \propto s_r]$

a. 지난 주에 **강아지 한 마리**를 입양했다.

b. 오늘 **강아지**가 사라졌다.

(Kim 2023b: (23))

- In (18), neither (10a) nor (10b) is met, so a Dem is required.
- In (19), (10a) is not met but (10b) is met, so an anaphoric bare noun is licensed; that is, here, **강아지** functions as a **text-internally licensed quasi-name**.

Extending to object positions in Korean

- Even though Kim's (2023b) analysis was developed based on the behavior of subject anaphoric definites which occur in two-sentence narratives, it can explain the following anaphoric object data in Korean, as well as what's given in (8) (i.e., the email case).

(20) When s_s introduces **just one** individual and $s_s \propto s_r$: (10a) is **not** met.

- a. **한 여학생**이 교실에서 공부하고 있다.
- b. 나는 ??/?(**그**) **여학생**을 만난 적이 있다. (박소영 2023: 주석 7 (i))

(21) When s_s introduces **two** individuals and $s_s \propto s_r$: (10a) **is** met.

- a. 철수는 하루 종일 **컴퓨터**를 수리했다.
- b. 그 후 공부방에 (**그**) **컴퓨터**를 놓아 두었다. (박소영 2023: (30))

Extending to donkey sentences in Korean

- Kim's (2023b) analysis explains the following donkey sentences in Korean:

(22) When the antecedent of a definite occurs in the antecedent of an **if-conditional**:

농부가 당나귀를 기르면 ?(그) 당나귀를 때린다.

(23) When the antecedent of a definite occurs inside a **relative clause (RC)**:

당나귀를 기르는 모든 농부는 ??(그) 당나귀를 때린다.

- (22) is made up of two full clauses and the first clause overtly introduces two individuals and the contents of the two clauses spatio-temporally overlap. So it is judged better than (23), where the antecedent of the definite occurs **not** in a full clause.
- That said, (22) is not perfect on the intended anaphoric reading because the antecedent of an *if*-conditional is not a sentence; it's a dependent clause.

Extending to donkey sentences cont'd

(24) When the antecedent of an **if-conditional** introduces **two objects**:

농부가 당나귀와 말을 기르면 (#그) 당나귀를 때린다.

(25) When the antecedent of an anaphoric definite occurs inside an **RC**:

당나귀와 말을 기르는 모든 농부는 ?/??(그) 당나귀를 때린다.

- On Kim's analysis, (24) **sort of** meets the presupposition of (11a), so an anaphoric bare noun **can** be licensed, though a generic reading is still strongly preferred.
- Using a Dem here is not so good because there is no pragmatic need to indicate a distal LR between the attitude holder and the donkey at issue.
- (25) has **greater difficulty** in meeting (11a) than (24) because it does not provide S_A (the RC is not a full clause). So using “그” is strongly preferred to obtain the intended anaphoric interpretation.

Extending to Mandarin Chinese

- Kim's (2023b) analysis can explain the following data from Mandarin Chinese.

- (26) a. Jiaoshi li zuo zhe yi ge nansheng he yi ge nüsheng.
classroom inside sit PROG one CLF boy and one CLF girl
'There are a boy and a girl sitting in the classroom.'
- b. Wo zuotian yudao **#(na ge) nansheng.**
I yesterday meet that CLF boy
'I met the boy yesterday.'

(Jenks 2018: (15a,b))

- In (26), s_s introduces two individuals **but** $\sim[s_s \propto s_r]$, so (10a) is not met and thus Dem + CL is necessary **unless** (10b) turns out to be met.

Extending to Mandarin Chinese cont'd

- Kim's analysis also explains the following Mandarin data.

- (27) a. Jiaoshi li zuo zhe yi ge nansheng he yi ge nüsheng.
classroom inside sit PROG one CLF boy and one CLF girl
'A boy and a girl are sitting in the classroom.'
- b. **Nüsheng** zuo zai **nansheng** pangbian.
girl sit DUR boy side
'The girl is sitting next to the boy.'

(Dayal and Jiang 2023: (11a,b))

- In (27), s_s introduces two individuals **and** $s_s \propto s_r$, so anaphoric bare nouns can be licensed (compare Dayal & Jiang 2023).

Applicability to bridging cases in Korean

- For bridging cases, Kim's (2023b) analysis only makes predictions about the **non-pronominal** anaphoric definite form that the **PR** takes; e.g., whether “그” in data like (4) and (5) can be replaced by a **Dem-NP** PR or an anaphoric **bare noun** PR.
- **Note:** 박소영 (2023) claims that what is pronounced as “그” in bridging data like (4) and (5) are **possessive pronouns**.

(4) 어제 매우 재미있는 논문을 읽었다. (그) 저자는 촌스키이다. (Product-Producer)

(5) 우리 집은 매우 오래된 집이다. (?그) 지붕은 빗물이 센다. (Part-Whole)

Applicability to bridging cases cont'd

- Under Kim's analysis, the PR of the anaphoric definite in (4) can be a **bare noun** or a **Dem-NP** (or a *pro*) because it meets both (10a) and (12).

(4') 어제 **매우 재미있는** 논문을 읽었다. [(그) 논문의/*pro*] 저자는 촌스키이다.

- As to (5), here, “**우리 집**” is the **topic**, so it is most naturally followed by a sentence that instantiates **external possession**, where the PR occurs external to the PM.
- Here, the PM-external PR of the anaphoric definite can only be “**우리 집**”, not “그 집”, because the speaker cannot indicate a distal LR to the home they live in when they're describing what's happening inside the house when they are in it.

(5') **우리 집**은 매우 오래된 집이다. (우리 집은) [*pro* 지붕]이 빗물이 센다.

(5'') **우리 집**은 매우 오래된 집이다. #(그 집은) [*pro* 지붕]이 빗물이 센다.

Potentially challenging case I

- (28) a. 리처드는 서점에 가서 그가 읽을 책 두 권을 샀다.
b. 책 두 권 중에 한 권은 길고 지루한 것이었다.
c. 하지만 **또 다른 한 권**은 정말 흥미로운 이야기로 구성되었다.
d. 그래서 리처드는 ***(그) 책을** 끝냈다. (Park 2023: (9)/(20), after Ionin 2012: (14c))

- Park (2023) claims that Kim's (2023b) analysis cannot account for the obligatory occurrence of the Dem “그” on the anaphoric definite in (28d).
- Again, Kim is **not** concerned with multi-sentence texts. However, if we are to apply her analysis to (28), then (28c) would constitute S_A , and (28d) S_D .
- But (28c) introduces **just one individual**, so the presupposition of (11a) is not met. Also, the anaphoric bare noun can**not** be treated as a text-internally unique quasi-name in (28d) yet. Therefore, “그” is required here.

Potentially challenging case II

- (29) a. 리처드는 서점에 가서 그가 읽을 책 두 권을 샀다.
b. 책 두 권 중에 한 권은 길고 지루한 것이었다.
c. 그래서 바로 **이 책을** 온라인에 팔았다.
d. 하지만 **또 다른 한 권은** 정말 흥미로운 이야기로 구성되었다.
e. **그것은** 그의 호기심을 크게 자극시켰다.
f. 그래서 리처드는 **(그) 책을** 끝냈다.

(Park 2023: (23)))

- Although Kim (2023b) is not concerned with multi-sentence texts or cases that contain pronouns like (29), in her analysis, the obligatory occurrence of “그” in (29e) would be predicted if a definite description (DD) “그 책” is used instead of the pronoun “그것”.
- As to the occurrence of the anaphoric bare noun “책” in (29f), it is licensed because in (29c), its text-level uniqueness is established; and in (29e), the use of the pronoun “그것” makes it **in focus** in the sense of Gundel et al. (1993). So, by the time speaker utters (29f), “책” can **name** both a situation-internally and text-internally unique entity that has *P*.

How to capture “recency effects” of a Dem-NP

- Dem-NPs in English exhibit so-called “**recency effects**” (Roberts 2002): a Dem-NP is construed as referring to the “last” or “just”-mentioned” entity if there are more than one x with the property P denoted by the NP in the discourse context (Wolter 2006; Ionin et al. 2012; Ahn 2023).
- The Korean facts parallel the English facts, as shown in (30)–(31).

(30) A woman₁ entered from stage left. Another woman₂ entered from stage right.
That woman_{2/*1} was carrying a basket of flowers.

(adapted from Wolter 2006: 4)

- (31) a. 한 여자가₁ 왼쪽 무대에서 들어 왔다.
b. 다른 여자가₂ 오른쪽 무대에서 들어 왔다.
c. 그 여자는_{2/*1} 꽃바구니를 들고 있었다.

How to capture “recency effects” of a Dem-NP

- Under the analysis presented in Kim 2023b, the recency effects illustrated in (30)–(31) may arise because a Dem-NP **presupposes** that its referent stands in an **LR** with the speaker in ***s_s***, and **asserts** that it still does in ***s_r***, so it wouldn't look for an antecedent in some previously uttered sentence when it can find one in the immediately preceding sentence.

(31) a. **한 여자가**₁ 왼쪽 무대에서 들어 왔다.
 b. **다른 여자가**₂ 오른쪽 무대에서 들어 왔다.
 c. **그 여자는**_{2/*1} 꽃바구니를 들고 있었다.

$$(13) \llbracket \text{Dem} \rrbracket^g = \lambda P_{\langle \text{et} \rangle}. \lambda G_{\langle \text{et} \rangle}. \exists ! x [P(x)(s_r) \ \& \ LR(x)(y)(s_s)] . \iota x [P(x)(s_r) \ \& \ LR(x)(y)(s_r) \ \& \ G(x)]$$

Presupposition
Assertion

How to capture “recency effects” of a Dem-NP cont’d

- (32) presents a seemingly more challenging case: Here, the 1st “그 여자” in (32c) must be co-indexed with the woman just introduced in (32b), and the 2nd “그 여자” must be co-indexed with the woman who was introduced in (32a).

- (32) a. 한 여자가₁ 왼쪽 무대에서 들어 왔다.
b. 다른 여자가₂ 오른쪽 무대에서 들어 왔다.
c. 그 여자가_{2/*1} 그 여자에게_{1/*2} 꽃을 주었다.

- Under Kim’s analysis, this puzzle can be explained as follows: the 1st occurrence of “그 여자” is **anaphorically** used, but the 2nd occurrence of “그 여자” is **situationally** used. That is, one is **discourse deictic** and the other is **spatio-temporally deictic** in the sense of Lakoff (1974).

- **What this shows:** Dem-NPs refer to an entity that is present in the **immediate discourse context**, whereas anaphoric bare nouns need not.

Conclusion

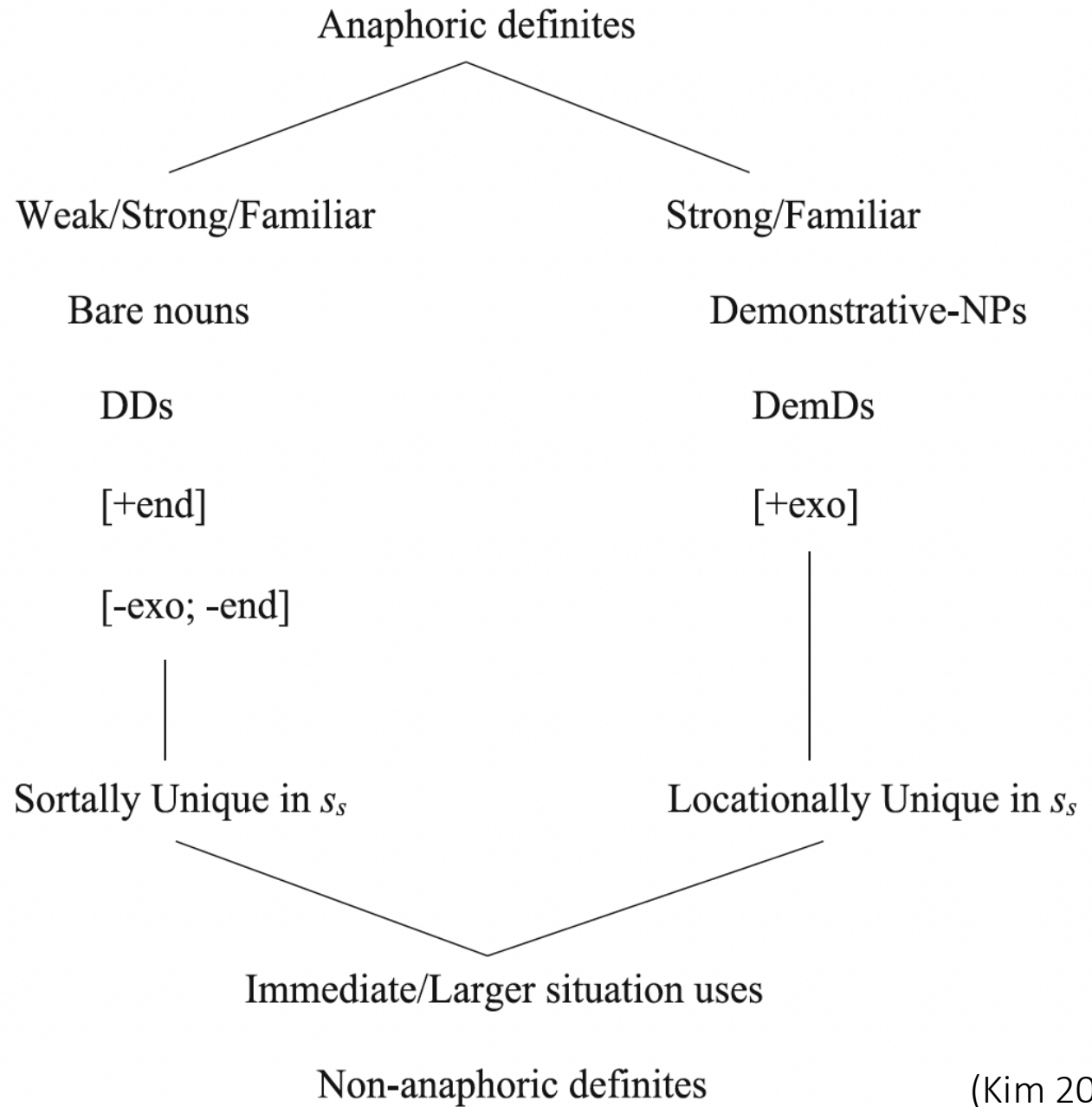
- What we have examined here suggests that the core ideas of Kim (2023b) are tenable:
 - Both bare noun definites and Dem-NPs encode uniqueness, but they perform different functions in marking definiteness in Korean (compare, a.o., 박소영 2023).
 - Anaphoric bare nouns are sortally unique; Dem-NPs are locationally unique (compare, a.o., Kang 2021; Löbner 1985).
 - Anaphoric bare noun are at least of two kinds: situation-internally licensed unique definites and text-internally licensed quasi-names (cf. Tomioka 2025).
 - Dems encode an LR between the speaker/attitude holder and another individual in the immediate discourse context (cf. Ionin et al. 2012).
 - Dems are inherently deictic (Diessel 1999; Roberts 2002); and they retain such a property even when used anaphorically (Lakoff 1974).

Conclusion cont'd

This classification is likely
to hold for Korean and
other (bare noun)
languages.

$$s_s \propto s_r$$

$$s_s \in T$$



Questions for future

- Which between bare noun and Dem-NP is the “**default**” form if choosing between them is possible (compare Ahn 2019; Kang 2021; Park & Kang 2024).
- Whether a more **unified analysis** of **all types of definites** in Korean and in other (bare noun) languages would be possible.
- Whether situationally used definites have a **different syntactic structure** than anaphorically used ones, be they realized as bare nouns or weak definites.

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Appendix: Types of definites based on Hawkins (1978) and Schwarz (2009)

	Type of definite use	Example from English
상황적	Immediate situation	Open <u>the door</u> !
	Larger situation	<u>The moon</u> has risen.
조응적	Typical anaphoric	John bought a book and a magazine today. <u>The book</u> was expensive.
	Bridging: Product-producer	John bought a book today. <u>The author</u> is French.
	Bridging: Part-whole	John bought a new house . <u>The ceiling</u> is very tall.
	Donkey anaphora	Every farmer that has a donkey beats <u>the donkey</u> .



Thank you!

감사합니다!

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